

CHALLENGES

PRICING

► GLP-1 drugs like semaglutide cost ₹10,000–20,000 per month, making them unaffordable for many in India

SIDE EFFECTS

► Gastrointestinal issues (nausea, vomiting, diarrhoea) and long-term risks such as cardiovascular effects require careful monitoring

REGULATORY NOD

► India's CDSCO is granting approvals, but post-marketing surveillance is necessary to assess safety

KEY WEIGHT-LOSS DRUG PIPELINE



SEMAGLUTIDE (OZEMPIC/WEGOVY)

- Initially approved for diabetes; off-label use for obesity is growing
- Trials show up to 15% body weight reduction over 68 weeks



TIRZEPATIDE (MOUNJARO/ZEPBOUND)

- Developed by Eli Lilly, targeting both GLP-1 and GIP hormones
- Trials show 20.9% weight loss at the highest dosage over 72 weeks



OTHER GLP-1 ANALOGUES:

- Drugs like liraglutide (Saxenda) and innovations from Novo Nordisk and Pfizer focus on both obesity and related comorbidities

2.5 mg and 15 mg. Tirzepatide had received approval in January 2024 for a single-dose prefilled pen format, as an adjunct to diet and exercise to improve glycaemic control in adults with Type 2 diabetes, but with the stipulation that Eli Lilly conduct Phase IV clinical trials in India.

Although Phase III trials for tirzepatide and semaglutide elsewhere have shown positive results, Indian authorities require domestic clinical data. So these drugs may take two to three years to become widely available in India after their global launch, according to doctors.

Then there are ethical concerns. Experts worry they could be misused for cosmetic weight loss rather than for managing clinical obesity. "Bariatric surgery remains the gold standard for some obese patients. We need awareness campaigns to ensure the drugs are used responsibly," says Dr Pradeep Chowbey, Chairman, Max Institute of Laparoscopic, Endoscopic, Bariatric Surgery & Allied Surgical Specialities.

Tirzepatide has already been approved for weight management and Type 2 diabetes, in combination with

diet and exercise, in the US and EU. In the US, the list price for a one-month supply is around \$1,087 (the exact price depends on insurance coverage, etc).

Eli Lilly has not notified the probable price of tirzepatide in India, but it may do so this year after the regulator clears it. "The current cost of semaglutide in India is approximately ₹10,000 per month. Tirzepatide will likely be priced similarly or higher, although the company can only confirm the exact price," says Dr Misra of Fortis C-Doc.

The potential for weight-loss medications such as semaglutide and tirzepatide to become mass treatments in India depends on cost and public demand, and they have to be cleared by the Drugs Controller General of India. If these drugs are shown to be cost-effective in preventing chronic diseases such as diabetes, hypertension, and cardiovascular conditions, there could be increased pressure for their inclusion in public health programmes or for private health insurers to offer coverage. **BT**

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